Food, farming and the countryside

1. Read the article once for meaning. 2. Read it again and look at the **highlighted new words** and the **blue phrases** in context. 3. Study the tables. 4. Use at least 5 new words in speaking or writing this week.

Article: Feeding the world: farming and food (172 words)

Agriculture has changed dramatically in the last century. A modern farmer uses **irrigation** and a chemical **fertilizer** to increase the **yield** of every **crop**, and an effective **pesticide** protects plants from insects, although it can harm bees. Healthy **soil** is vital, and a **fertile** valley can support many farms. At harvest time, the **harvest** is moved to cities, and **livestock** farmers supply meat and milk.

Opinion is divided over new methods. Supporters of **genetically modified** seed argue that it can prevent **famine**, while many consumers prefer **organic** products that avoid chemicals. In poorer regions, **subsistence** farmers grow only enough to feed their own families, while **rural** communities lose young people to cities. Because **imported** goods travel far, the idea of reducing **food miles** has gained support.

Good **nutrition** depends on a varied diet rich in **nutrient** sources, and every national **cuisine** reflects its history and climate. Methods of **preservation**, such as drying and salting, have kept food safe for centuries. The task now is to **feed a growing population** without **using up** the land.

Useful phrases from the article

Phrase	Meaning
feed a growing population	provide enough food for more people
using up	exhausting

The 20 new words

Word		Meaning	Example
agriculture	n	the science and practice of farming	*Agriculture employs half the population.*
crop	n	a plant grown for food	*Wheat is the main crop here.*
harvest	n	the gathering of ripe crops	*The harvest was poor this year.*
livestock	n	animals kept on a farm	*Livestock need fresh water.*
fertilizer	n	a substance added to soil to help plants grow	*Too much fertilizer harms rivers.*
irrigation	n	supplying land with water	*Irrigation turned the desert green.*
organic	adj	grown without chemicals	*Organic vegetables cost more.*

genetically modified	adj	changed by altering genes	*Genetically modified crops resist disease.*
famine	n	a severe shortage of food	*The famine lasted two years.*
nutrient	n	a substance needed for growth	*Vegetables are rich in nutrients.*
rural	adj	in the countryside	*Rural areas lack services.*
subsistence	n	having just enough to live	*Subsistence farmers grow their own food.*
yield	n	the amount a crop produces	*New seeds increased the yield.*
pesticide	n	a chemical that kills insects	*Pesticides can harm bees.*
soil	n	the top layer of the ground	*Healthy soil is full of life.*
fertile	adj	good for growing plants	*The valley is very fertile.*
cuisine	n	a style of cooking	*Italian cuisine is popular worldwide.*
imported	adj	brought in from another country	*Imported fruit is available all year.*
food miles	n	the distance food travels to be eaten	*Shopping locally reduces food miles.*
preservation	n	keeping food from going bad	*Salt was used for preservation.*

Revision: 10 words from last week

Word		Meaning
galaxy	n	a huge group of stars
orbit	n	the path of an object around another
planet	n	a large body that moves around a star
telescope	n	an instrument for seeing distant objects
gravity	n	the force that pulls objects together
satellite	n	an object that circles a planet
space exploration	n	the study of outer space by travel
asteroid	n	a small rocky body in space
atom	n	the smallest part of a chemical element
radiation	n	energy sent out as waves or particles

Practice: fill the gaps

famine · food miles · cuisine · soil · subsistence · pesticide · nutrient · irrigation

1. The _____ lasted two years.
2. Shopping locally reduces _____.
3. Italian _____ is popular worldwide.
4. Healthy _____ is full of life.
5. _____ farmers grow their own food.
6. _____ can harm bees.
7. Vegetables are rich in _____.
8. _____ turned the desert green.

More words on this topic (not in the article: choose the 10 most useful for you)

barn (n): a farm building for storing crops
cattle (n): cows kept for meat or milk
cereal (n): a grain crop such as wheat
compost (n): decayed plant matter for soil
dairy (n): milk products
dehydrated (adj): with the water removed
diet (n): the food a person eats
drought-resistant (adj): able to survive without rain
farmland (n): land used for farming
fertility (n): the ability to produce crops
fishery (n): a place where fish are caught
fodder (n): food for animals
grain (n): the seeds of cereal plants
greenhouse (n): a glass building for plants
herb (n): a plant used in cooking
horticulture (n): the growing of garden plants
labor-intensive (adj): needing a lot of workers
machinery (n): machines used on a farm
monoculture (n): growing one crop only
orchard (n): a place where fruit trees grow
paddy (n): a flooded field for rice
perishable (adj): likely to go bad soon
plow (v): to turn the soil
poultry (n): birds kept for eggs and meat
produce (n): food grown on a farm
ripe (adj): ready to be eaten
seed (n): the part of a plant that grows a new one
sow (v): to plant seeds
staple (n): a basic food
sustenance (n): food that keeps you alive

Answers

1. famine (famine)
2. food miles (food miles)
3. cuisine (cuisine)
4. soil (soil)
5. Subsistence (subsistence)
6. Pesticides (pesticide)
7. nutrients (nutrient)
8. Irrigation (irrigation)